

At 91, Dale Sanders Reclaims Appalachian Trail Age Record

From: DOGOnews Mined: 2026-10-03 5 min read

Dale Sanders of Memphis, Tennessee, became the oldest person to hike the entire Appalachian Trail on August 31, 2026. At 91, he completed the 2,198-mile route in 359 days, **reclaiming** a record he had first set nine years earlier.

The Appalachian Trail runs from Springer Mountain in Georgia to Mount Katahdin in Maine. Its route includes forests, mountains and rocky **terrain**. According to the report, an official completion requires hikers to cover the entire trail within 365 days, but they do not have to make one **continuous** trip. Sections may be completed in different orders, with breaks between them.

That flexibility shaped Sanders' journey. He started on September 6, 2025, in Harpers Ferry, West Virginia, near the trail's **midpoint**. He chose his route so he could see Georgia's autumn leaves. During winter, he paused to avoid hiking in snow. He returned in spring and continued north toward Maine.

Sanders averaged about 12 miles a day, with one rest day each week. Even with those breaks, the journey tested his **endurance**. Only about a third of the more than 3,000 people who attempt the trail each year finish it, according to the report.

After a fall in Vermont, Sanders later experienced numbness in his left arm and went to a hospital in Maine. Tests identified a pinched nerve. He was eventually allowed to **resume** hiking. Exhausted and considering stopping, he received encouragement from family and supporters with 140 miles left.

Sanders first became the trail's oldest finisher in 2017, when he was 82. His friend M.J. Eberhart completed it at 83 in 2021, breaking that record with Sanders' encouragement. Watching his friend succeed helped prompt Sanders to seek the record again.

His other achievements include paddling the full Mississippi River at 80 and again at 87, and completing a 42-mile Grand Canyon hike at 85. Sanders credits daily exercise and a positive attitude for his ability to keep tackling long-distance challenges.

Word Treasure

reclaiming -- Getting back something previously held.

terrain -- The features and surface of an area of land.

continuous -- Continuing without a break.

midpoint -- A point near the middle of something.

endurance -- The ability to keep making an effort for a long time.

resume -- To begin again after stopping.

Background you need

The Appalachian Trail connects Springer Mountain in Georgia with Mount Katahdin in Maine. Sanders' other reported challenges included paddling the Mississippi River and completing a 42-mile Grand Canyon hike.

Break it down

Opens with the new age record, completion date and trail distance.

Explains the trail's endpoints and reported completion rules.

Describes Sanders' route choice and seasonal schedule.

Places the effort in context with a reported completion rate.

Describes his health setback and encouragement near the finish.

Closes with the record's history, other achievements and Sanders' view of endurance.

Why it matters

The story connects a personal achievement with US geography and shows how a long hiking journey involved route planning, breaks, medical care and encouragement.

Test what you remember

1. What are the two ends of the Appalachian Trail?
 - (A) Harpers Ferry and Mount Katahdin
 - (B) Memphis and the Grand Canyon
 - (C) Springer Mountain and Mount Katahdin
 - (D) Springer Mountain and Harpers Ferry
2. Which approach is allowed under the completion rules described in the report?
 - (A) Hiking selected sections repeatedly within 365 days
 - (B) Completing the whole route over several separate years
 - (C) Completing only the mountain sections within 365 days
 - (D) Hiking sections in different orders within 365 days
3. Why did Sanders choose his route through Georgia?
 - (A) To finish beside the Mississippi River
 - (B) To avoid every rocky trail section
 - (C) To meet his friend at the summit
 - (D) To see its colorful autumn leaves
4. According to the report, about what share of people attempting the trail finish it?
 - (A) About two thirds
 - (B) About one third
 - (C) About one half
 - (D) About one tenth
5. What did hospital tests identify as the cause of Sanders' arm numbness?
 - (A) A strained muscle
 - (B) A pinched nerve
 - (C) A broken bone
 - (D) A swollen joint
6. How did Sanders respond to Eberhart's attempt to break his earlier record?
 - (A) He suggested a different trail
 - (B) He asked his friend to wait
 - (C) He joined his friend's entire hike
 - (D) He encouraged his friend's attempt

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: D 3: D 4: B 5: B 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Dale Sanders: Sanders credits daily exercise and a positive attitude for his ability to keep taking on long-distance challenges.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):